Individual Assignment Cover Sheet

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I. Introduction

This assessment is focused on discussing negotiation as a vital life skill balancing communication, judgement, decision-making, and conflict resolution. As outlined in the *Negotiations Lab* course (De Rond, 2025), it involves both rational and intuitive problem-solving across various contexts.

This work reflects on my diary, integrating insights from real-world case studies and simulations. It examines preparation, framing, and emotional intelligence in resolving conflicts, improving decision-making, and enabling cooperation across industries and international settings. It also includes learnings from plenary sessions featuring a distinguished astronaut and an MP discussing Brexit negotiations.

By this assessment, I am pleased to confirm that I have thoroughly covered the five core books from the required reading: Fisher, Ury & Patton (2011), Kahneman (2011), Malhotra (2016), Stone, Patton & Heen (1999), and Voss (2016). These works provided complementary perspectives on negotiation, communication, and decision-making. Initially sceptical about the effectiveness of a negotiation “Lab” given time and resource constraints, I found that peer interactions and lecture reflections significantly enriched my learning.

II. Strategies Evaluation

Below are shown the different strategies highlighted during the course and linked to the respective negotiation sessions.

Negotiate based on Interests

A consistent approach recommended by Fisher, Ury and Patton (2011, pp.40-48) was to negotiate under interests and not positions. This process seemed to be applied successfully for the Salt Harbor Scenario (Wheeler, 2002). While negotiating a real estate development deal balancing financial interests and long-term community impact, a rational approach was likely to govern this situation given the clear interests of both parts. There was a set of incremental concessions as described by Martin, Goldstein, and Cialdini (2014, pp.115-117) to ensure that both entities were satisfied. The outcome was satisfactory, but sometime addressing interest is not enough this as presented in some of the upcoming scenarios.

Reframing and empathic negotiation

MedLee’s scenario (Lun and Salacuse, 2018) on establishing a joint venture between American and Asian firms while managing was a good testing context for negotiating given cultural and strategic differences. Malhotra (2016, pp.121-124) refers to the effectiveness on presenting interests within the right framing and authentic empathy.

Witnessing how both parts were getting frustrated on not moving on executive board and evaluating performance from the Lee family, further context was required to

ensure that there was a clear strategy derived from a respectful identity and learning conversation as recommended by Stone, Patton and Heen (1999, pp.14-17). The results were reached by the end of the negotiation ensuring that the Lees could maintain their identity while staying flexible and dynamic for the venture with MedDevice.

Negotiate with interests, mediation and emotions.

The PowerScreen contract dispute (Patton, Gordon & Clarkson, 2018) highlighted the role of emotions in negotiations alongside royalties, financial terms, and business continuity. The video played during the class demonstrated that emotions played a crucial role, yet the dispute had a clear cause. Fisher and Shapiro (2005, pp. 15-30) stress addressing concerns before emotions. Hacker sought recognition as well as financial compensation. As his lawyer, I highlighted his concerns, advocating for understanding before shifting focus to keeping the company running. Without mediation, dissolution was likely.

I framed the situation as a misunderstanding, aligning with Star's interests (Ashford & Detert, 2015), ensuring cooperation (Lax & Sebenius, 1986, pp. 261-278), and fostering a successful agreement (Moore, 2014, pp. 477-486). We kept both the company and their relationship.

Coalition forming in negotiations

The Grand Afroport negotiation (Mehta, 2017) required applying new skills to secure a public-private partnership for airport infrastructure. The focus was on finding a solution that balanced most interests. Greene (1998, pp. 250-256) highlights coalition-building as a strategy to strengthen influence, leverage power, and isolate opposition. This approach helped three parties reach consensus while marginalising a less cooperative player.

Once the coalition formed, mutually beneficial solutions became easier to achieve, enabling teamwork even in high-stakes negotiations (Maxwell, 2007, pp. 255-259). Ultimately, the negotiation resulted in agreement on building the port, with one party being excluded as a consequence of seeking only their top desired interests.

Security (and empathy) consensus on negotiations

This strategy was used to handle the most emotionally and intellectually demanding negotiation (according to most peers). The WTC reconstruction negotiation (Susskind et al., 2019) caused friction as some students had personal ties to the real event. One player deviated from their role, framing arguments through a nationalistic lens. The student ignored instructions for their role and felt significantly involved and aimed to get the mediator to shared specific views against other players.

Team members addressed the identity concerns mentioned above with emotional intelligence, following Fisher and Shapiro's (2005, pp. 129-146) approach. Kahneman

(2011, pp. 31-38) stresses the need to resist System 1 thinking and remain rational. Despite the emotional remarks from this student, the approach wad to listen, acknowledge and reframe their role to follow the instructions for their role. A respectful identity conversation took place with the student, as advised by Stone, Patton, and Heen (1999, pp. 111-117), ensured emotions were acknowledged. Finally, the team built coalitions and reached an option satisfying most parties.

III. Self-learning

Below are some key insights I gained about myself while reflecting on the negotiations.

Importance of preparation: It was clear based on interactions on all the exercises about preparing well enough for the task to be done strengthens any talent as stated Maxwell, J.C. (2007, pp.83-88). Reading in detail about the cases, and then access to related news, allowed me to leverage key information during the negotiations. Unfortunately for their learning, underperformers during the negotiations tended to use GenAI to get summaries of the instructions and their positions.

Do not make assumptions: The PowerScreen scenario had a very strong bias context by watching the video. From my perspective there was a strong assumption that Hacker was a very emotional reactive character. As his lawyer, I ensured that our negotiation was based on understanding the psychology behind Star as the manager as recommended by Lax (1986, pp.261-268), allowing us to eliminate assumptions about his Hacker's behaviour.

Have a clear objective and quantifiable framework: As addressed by Kahneman (2011, pp.212-221) having a focused quantifiable framework (in my case using spreadsheets with weighted calculations) allowed me to use System 2 more efficiently and removed the noise. As introduced in the course having also a framework on 9 relevant dimensions in a worksheet (De Rond, 2025) to assess the negotiation parties played critical.

Framing information is key: Kahneman and MP. In the first two negotiations, I tended to provide my positions and interests very straight forward. I realised that it is critical to present options to my counter parts in the right sequence and context as suggested by Malhotra (2016, pp.121-124). Likewise, by preparing the decision makers by giving them relevant information with enough anticipation, prevents them to felt rushed, with a sense of ownership as it was the case for influencing PM as Margaret Thatcher and Tony Blair (Wilson, 2025).

Leverage your information and power: Although it was not possible to read other player instructions, it was critical from my side to let my counterparts to speak more than me applying the 70:30 rule suggested by professional negotiators in hostage situations (Brooks, 2025). I.e. during the Afroport case, I gained enough information to understand that my role as the Bank was the strongest with the enablement to veto the whole exercise if there was not a satisfactory outcome, and leverage that power with boldness, as ruled in by Greene (1998, pp 423-430).

IV. Learning from others

Assertive Communication: During the WTC exercise, and the student getting emotional, it was critical to assert authentic empathy only we I had experienced a similar circumstance. We were careful on stating “I can only imagine how hard could this be to you and your closed ones” similar to security negotiations (Brookes, 2025).

Be-aware of saboteurs: As highlighted by Greene in terms of people wearing masks (2018, pp.70-78), there can several reasons for saboteurs to be present in a group. This was a relevant out of the box realisation I had from the Afroport case. Unfortunately, it was too late to know it was the environmentalist during the exercise.

Identity is critical to address**:** MedLee scenario, proved to have the Lee family role to be very reactive, and settle on their ways of doing business as a family. It took several iterations to ensure they understood the position from MedDevice under the right arguments and while understanding and keeping their identity as covered by Stone, Patton and Heen (1999, pp.116-117).

Emotional Intelligence is fundamental: Fisher and Shapiro (2005, pp 147-152) let me reflect on using emotions constructively during the WTC exercise. Likewise, I was inspired by how a high-ranking public officer (Wilson, 2025) was not emotionally involved in critical decisions for national security during September 11 attacks. Within a calculated and prudent approach, he decided towards evacuating a critical building in London, and provide calm and cooperative direction at 10 Downing St.

Build syndicates if relevant: Power sharing is relevant to form coalitions leading to consensus as highlighted by Greene (2018, pp.251-256). Both in the Afroport and WTC reconstruction this was critical. I managed to first listen to those who were more benefitted by my Bank and Developer roles, respectively, and form a small coalition to push for our share interests but also aimed to satisfy at least most of everyone’s requirements.

Fully differentiate preferable from not acceptable: As recommended by Fisher, Ury and Patton (2011, pp.40-48) it is critical to negotiate addressing the underlying interests rather than the represented roles. The WTC was almost failing as a negotiation since some team members focused more on their positions and actual nationalities rather than facts and interests. The whole negotiation changed when it we differentiate preferable outcomes from not-acceptable at all given our interests.

Plenary Sessions

This diary assessment would not be completed without commenting on our plenary sessions.

***Astronaut and ISS Training*:** Teamwork, negotiation, and communication are crucial for ISS astronauts to coordinate tasks, resolve conflicts, and ensure mission success (Metclaf-Lindenburger, 2025). Effective collaboration enhances safety, problem-solving, and international cooperation in the high-stakes space environment. Critical, on-time and factual communication is critical to ensuring saving lives in high performing elite teams as highlighted by Willink and Babin (2015, pp.83-89).

Brexit Negotiations: A detailed narrative was presented on how David Cameron's Brexit was a failed strategy. It lacked clear risk assessment, over-relied on polls, misjudged public sentiment, and failed contingency planning post-referendum (Bilmoria, 2025) with Lord Bilmoria.

Brexit negotiations needed clearer trade terms, realistic timeframes, and proactive solutions for Northern Ireland's border to prevent disruptions. Framing in public service is critical (Wilson, 2025) and Cameron should have taken a full ownership of this outcome as recommended by Willink and Babin (2015, pp.37-42) showing poor leadership execution. Instead, a chaotic succession of PMs lacked solid strategies to reach in time a good deal with the EU.

V. Conclusion

This assessment has provided valuable insights into negotiation strategies, including interest-based bargaining, reframing, mediation, coalition-building, and emotional intelligence. By applying theories from key readings such as Fisher, Ury & Patton (2011), Kahneman (2011), Malhotra (2016), and Greene (1998), I have developed a deeper understanding of effective negotiation techniques across various contexts.

The case studies reinforced the importance of preparation, strategic framing, and adapting to cultural and emotional dynamics. Exercises such as the Salt Harbor and MedLee scenarios highlighted how addressing interests rather than positions leads to constructive outcomes. The PowerScreen dispute and WTC negotiations underscored the critical role of emotional intelligence, as outlined by Fisher & Shapiro (2005). Meanwhile, the Afroport case demonstrated coalition-building's effectiveness in high-stakes settings (Maxwell, 2007).

Reflections on self-learning highlighted the need for structured preparation, avoiding assumptions, and leveraging decision-making frameworks (Kahneman, 2011). Plenary sessions, particularly those on Brexit and astronaut training, reinforced leadership, risk assessment, and crisis communication lessons.

Overall, this experience has enhanced my ability to navigate complex negotiations, combining rational problem-solving with strategic adaptability. By integrating theoretical knowledge with practical application, I have strengthened my negotiation skills for both professional and real-world scenarios.

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